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THE LOST KINGDOM

SO FAR, the Pakistan Super League has done well. It had to. We didn't have a choice, especially with the Indian Premier League and the Bangladesh Premier League (BPL) preceding us in the subcontinent.

With the PSL, strategically at least, we have achieved our goals. New talent has emerged. An example from the first PSL is Hassan Ali. Another one is Mohammad Nawaz. These boys are a living testament to the overdue emergence of young, fresh talent. But Pakistan's biggest problem still remains our batting. Despite the PSL, not enough promising batsmen are emerging. But bowlers are. If you ask me, I think this is a geographical issue. I know it sounds a bit far-fetched but bear with me. I have a theory about this.

I call our batting problem our Karachi problem. Karachi – our biggest, toughest, roughest city by the sea, in the south – was famous for its batsmen. Meanwhile, Punjab, our great province in the east, has traditionally been famous for its bowlers. There was an easy 'division of labour' between Karachi and Punjab. Simple.

I'm not sure how this specialization started but it was well in place by the time I started playing. We Karachiwalas batted well. The Punjab boys, and boys from further up north, bowled better. It's just how things worked. It was in our blood.

But as the developmental disparity between Karachi and Punjab kept climbing, so did our cricketing standards. One issue was the nature of cricket academies. Lahore has the only functional academy in the country. Multan, in southern Punjab, is getting one too. Karachi's academy hasn't been inaugurated despite almost a decade of trying. Blame bureaucracy. Blame the rule of the Pakistan People's Party. Blame apathy. Blame the shitshow that is Karachi.

But also: blame trends. The disappearance of cement pitches – a Karachi-centric phenomenon, although it can now be found nationwide – has hurt our batting standards.

Cement pitches improve your batting. The ball comes in fast and hard; even a medium-pacer can end up hurting you with the extra bounce a cement pitch offers. The irony is that playing in